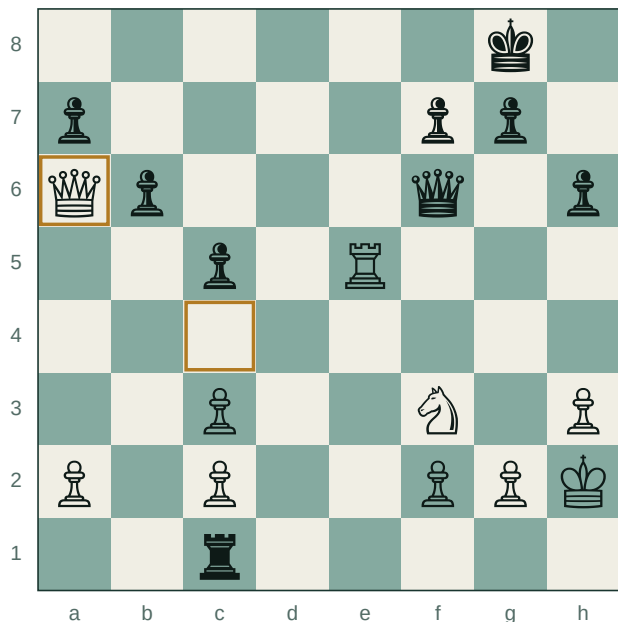


Deflection tactics: Black, move 24

Deflection tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 24.Qa6. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

24...Qf4+ 25. g3 Qxf3 26. Re8+ Kh7 27. Qd3+ Qxd3

24...Qf4+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. From f4 it attacks king on h2, rook on e5 and knight on f3. Recorded reply: **25.g3**.

25...Qxf3 The queen captures the knight on f3. Recorded reply: **26.Re8+**.

26...Kh7 The king moves from g8 to h7. Recorded reply: **27.Qd3+**.

27...Qxd3 The queen captures the queen on d3.

At the end, nominal material is White 11 / Black 20 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +12. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +12:** the balance goes from -3 to +9. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A replacement defender or an intermediate check can keep the target safe even after the original defender moves.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Deflection distracts a defender from a critical job. Its new square matters less than the fact that it no longer guards the original target.

HOW TO LOOK

Name the defender's job, find a forcing way to divert it, and calculate the move that exploits the abandoned square.

The defending king is on h2. Geometrically undefended: queen on a6. Check for tactical protection.